

PHILLY FORCE
The 76ers' Allen Iverson soars for 39 points as Philly tops the Pacers, 114-110. D3



BASEBALL
Cardinals cut former Indian Carlos Baerga. D4

NFL
Instant replay gets the green light. D5

PREP BASKETBALL
LCC announces its all-stars. D4

Sports

The Chronicle / THURSDAY, MARCH 18, 1999 D1

Sexson showing signs of life

Chris Assenheimer
The Chronicle-Telegram

WINTER HAVEN, Fla. — Better put Richie Sexson's reservations for Buffalo on hold. The young slugger, whose early spring training woes at the plate seemed to signal a return to the minors, has begun to creep out of a funk that saw him collect just two hits in his first 25 exhibition at-bats.

As a result, Sexson is back in the race with veteran Wil Cordero for the designated hitter spot

Relaxed approach has slugger back in the race for Tribe DH job

in the Indians' lineup.

The 24-year-old first baseman/outfielder, who made a big impression on the Indians while filling in for an injured Jim Thome last season, made another one Wednesday in an 8-2 victory over the Tampa Bay Devil Rays at Chain of Lakes Park.

Sexson went 3-for-4, driving in four runs with a triple and a mammoth home run off Tampa Bay starter Tony Saunders in the second inning. The homer, Sexson's second of the spring, cleared the grandstands behind the left-field wall, landing some 450 feet from home plate.

It was another day of progress for Sexson, who is 7-for-14 after the horrible start and has raised his average to a modest .230.

"Really, the last four or five days, Richie's been swinging the bat better," said Tribe manager Mike Hargrove, who admitted he would be disappointed if Sexson does not win the job over Cordero. "We've given him a lot of extra batting practice and he's swinging the bat with more authority. He's more firm up there. Richie's doing a lot of things right, right now."

And feeling better doing them. "I'm feeling better at the

See **SEXSON**, D2



COMING THROUGH: The Tribe's Richie Sexson, in background, rounds third Wednesday after hitting a long solo home run off Tampa Bay starter Tony Saunders.

Hit the boards

OSU concerned about Auburn's inside strength

Roger Negin
The Chronicle-Telegram

KNOXVILLE, Tenn. — Perhaps the season's most surprising teams from arguably the two best conferences will collide here tonight in the second semifinal game of the NCAA South Regional.

It'll be fourth-seeded Ohio State (25-8) against top-seeded Auburn (29-3) at the University of Tennessee's Thompson-Boling Arena.

The game will start about a half hour after the other semifinal between second-seeded Maryland and third-seeded St. John's ends. That one will tip off at 7:38.

The two winners will meet here Saturday at 6 p.m. for a trip to Tampa and the Final Four.

"You could look at this almost like a Final Four," said Auburn coach Cliff Ellis, whose team stunned the basketball world by winning the SEC regular-season title.

"Duke isn't here, but any of these teams could be there. Whoever comes out of this region will represent the region well.

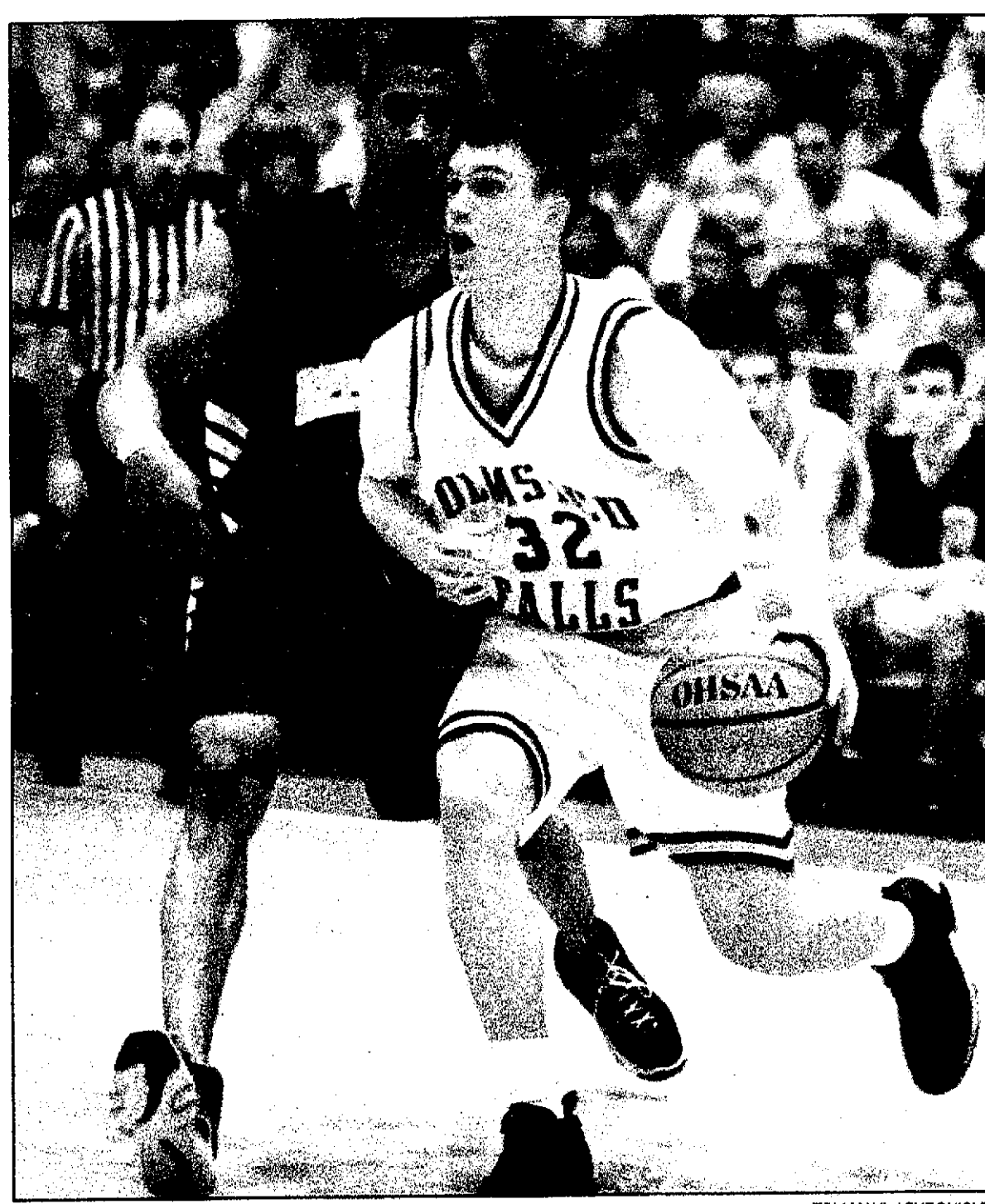
"Not only will you see a great basketball game, but two great ones."

Rebounding should be the key for both Auburn and Ohio State. Auburn is second in the country behind Duke in scoring margin, beating their opponents by 20.3 points a game.

The Tigers are 11th in points

See **OSU**, D2

THE TOURNAMENT TRAIL: HIGH SCHOOL BASKETBALL



GOOD DRIVER: Falls' Sean Radigan brings the ball up against Beechcroft's Marchello Cox.

One half sinks Falls

Defense, foul shooting leave 'Dogs dazed in regional loss

Bob Daniels
The Chronicle Telegram

BOWLING GREEN — Manzie Williams shot the lights out and Olmsted Falls ran off 15 straight points to jump all over Columbus Beechcroft Wednesday night.

The Bulldogs' domination lasted a half.

Beechcroft (19-4) turned up the defense after halftime, denied Williams the ball and denied Olmsted Falls a shot at a Division II regional championship.

The Bulldogs fell 69-58 and go home with a 21-3 record, having walked away with the Southwestern Conference championship and their sixth district tournament title of the 1990s, their fourth in five years.

They've won one regional game in that time.

"One of these days, I'm going to figure out how to win this regional," said Olmsted Falls coach Pat Donohue.

Defense and free throws. They win a lot of basketball games and they won for the Cougars.

Williams scored 17 points the first half, blistering the nets with five 3-point baskets in six shots. The Cougar defense, working to keep the ball away

from him after the break, held him to four points the rest of the way.

Free throws? The Cougars were 12 of 16 for the night, 9 of 12 in the fourth quarter when they put this one away.

Beechcroft meets Lima Shawnee, winner of Wednesday night's first game, for the regional championship at 7:30 Saturday night.

"In our first five or six games, we were 75 percent free-throw shooters," Donohue said. "We shot 69 or 70 percent most of the season."

"This poor foul shooting has happened in the last week or so. We're down to about 60 percent, but what can you do? It gets in the kids' heads. You hope you get the right people to the foul line, but that's part of the game."

The smaller Bulldogs went against a 6-foot-8 post player, senior Delano Thomas, but neither 6-4 sophomore Mike Gansy nor any of the other Falls players in the paint were intimidated by him.

See **FALLS**, D5

Spartans excited to join Toledo football conference

Luke Sullivan
The Chronicle-Telegram

After 12 years competing as an independent, the Lorain Catholic football team will finally have a chance to play for a conference championship.

The Spartans are entering the Toledo Area Athletic Conference for the 1999 football season.

"We already play two schools in the conference, and now that

See **SPARTANS**, D5

Ready or not, Cavs know it's Showtime

Rick Noland
The Chronicle-Telegram

CLEVELAND — It might not help the Cavs' record, but it will put some extra cash in team owner Gordon Gund's wallet.

Due to the prolonged NBA lockout, Michael Jordan's retirement and another year of mediocrity on the local team's part, tonight's 7:30 game against the Los Angeles Lakers could be the Cavs' first — and only — sellout this season.

As of Wednesday afternoon, approximately 1,000 tickets remained, guaranteeing the Cavs

TONIGHT

WHO: Cavs vs. Lakers
TIME: 7:30
WHERE: Gund Arena
TV/RADIO: Fox Sports Ohio, WTAM 1100-AM

(10-10) of their largest crowd this year.

The Lakers (17-7), who had won 10 straight until losing to Sacramento on Sunday, may not be the best team in the league, but they are easily the most glamorous now that Jordan isn't leading Chicago to another NBA title.

"I don't know anybody who feels good about playing the Lakers," Cavs coach Mike Fratello said. "That's a tough assignment."

In rapper and movie star Shaquille O'Neal, 20-year-old phenom Kobe Bryant and tattoo-bearing, hair-coloring, Carmen Electra-marrying Dennis Rodman, Los Angeles features three of the most recognizable players in the league.

Of course, no one really knows when Rodman is going to return and what will happen when — or if — he does, but that sort of fits

See **CAVS**, D2

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